

Your closer, usually a title representative, will give you a time and date for the closing. Plan to be there fifteen minutes early, and make sure to bring a government-issued ID and any funds you did not wire. (Ask your closing representative if there is a limit on funds you can bring to closing with a cashier's check. There has been an uptick in cashier's check fraud, and many title companies have very low limits for check acceptance.)

Right before your closing time, your agent will schedule an hour or so for a final walk-through. Make sure they do this, since this is your last chance to check out the property. During this hour, you can make sure the sellers didn't do anything they weren't supposed to, like punch fresh holes in what are about to be your walls. Check for any inclusions or exclusions that were in your contract, and keep an eye out for any damage. Usually, everything is hunky-dory, but this is your opportunity to double-check that the seller isn't trying to run off with the washer and dryer they were supposed to leave behind.

Last but not least, start lifting weights with your dominant hand—because you're going to be signing your name, a lot. Closing takes between 60 and 120 minutes, which is filled to the brim with signing and initialing a stack of official documentation.

Once everything is signed, you will get a set of keys to the house. (Assuming, of course, your possession date and closing date are the same.) You're allowed a cheesy picture or two to celebrate your success—we won't judge. Hold those keys high and bare your goofiest, slap-happiest grin to the camera.

You are now a homeowner. Congratulations!